WASHINGTON, DC, UNITED STATES

Smithsonian American Art Museum: Masterpieces

Twenty works that distinguish an attentive image from a complete account of a life.



Hopper's woman leans towards something outside the picture; the museum's discussion acknowledges that her object of attention is unknown. Lawrence's library gives looking and reading a shared public setting. Catlin's portraits and ceremonial scenes raise a different question: how much can an image made by an outsider tell us about the people it represents?

This selection treats attention as both a pictorial arrangement and a social relationship. A named sitter should not disappear into a general category, and a small painted figure cannot speak for an entire community. Landscapes and still lifes belong here too. Their apparently straightforward observations are shaped by decisions about distance, selection and what deserves to occupy the centre.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/smithsonian-american-art

The selection · 20

1. Cape Cod Morning
   Edward Hopper · 1950
2. The Farmer's Kitchen
   Ivan Albright · 1934
3. The Library
   Jacob Lawrence · 1960
4. Aurora Borealis
   Frederic Edwin Church · 1865
5. The Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone
   Thomas Moran · 1893-1901
6. The Girl I Left Behind Me
   Eastman Johnson · c. 1872
7. A Visit from the Old Mistress
   Winslow Homer · 1876
8. The Lord Is My Shepherd
   Eastman Johnson · 1863
9. Brothers
   Malvin Gray Johnson · 1934
10. Self-Portrait
    Malvin Gray Johnson · 1934
11. Elizabeth Winthrop Chanler
    John Singer Sargent · 1893
12. Mother: Annie Williams Gandy
    Thomas Eakins · c. 1903
13. Melons and Morning Glories
    Raphaelle Peale · 1813
14. The Old Arrow Maker
    Edmonia Lewis · 1872
15. The Bride
    Abbott Handerson Thayer · c. 1895
16. Blind Spanish Singer
    Robert Henri · 1912
17. Choctaw Woman
    George Catlin · 1834
18. Smoking Horses
    George Catlin · 1835-1836
19. Bitterroot
    Mary Vaux Walcott · 1915
20. Interior with Portraits
    Thomas Le Clear · c. 1865

01 / 20

Cape Cod Morning

Edward Hopper

1950 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Edward Hopper. Cape Cod Morning. WikiArt source label: Edward Hopper Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/edward-hopper/cape-cod-morning · Edward Hopper Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The woman's forward lean makes her attention unmistakable, but its cause remains beyond the frame. Hopper divides the projecting window from the bright landscape without granting the viewer her view. This is a useful limit to keep: the pose can appear expectant without proving that she awaits a visitor or fears a specific event. The watching body is the evidence available.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Farmer's Kitchen

Ivan Albright

1934 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Ivan Albright. The Farmer's Kitchen. WikiArt source label: Ivan Albright Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/ivan-albright/the-farmer-s-kitchen · Ivan Albright Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Albright refuses to let domestic work settle into a softly generalised image of homeliness. The woman's skin, vegetables and worn kitchen surfaces all receive insistent detail. Age and use extend across the setting rather than belonging to her face alone. The accumulated marks make labour a material condition of the room, not simply an activity performed within it.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

The Library

Jacob Lawrence

1960 · Tempera on board · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Jacob Lawrence. The Library. WikiArt source label: Jacob Lawrence Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jacob-lawrence/the-library-1960 · Jacob Lawrence Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Lawrence gathers readers around tables without appointing one distinguished person as the scene's centre. Repeated shapes connect shelves, furniture and bodies, while differences of pose keep the participants separate. Reading is represented as access to a shared space and its resources. The simplified colour areas make that collective arrangement easier to grasp without erasing the individual acts of attention within it.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Aurora Borealis

Frederic Edwin Church

1865 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Frederic Edwin Church. Aurora Borealis. Frederic Edwin Church; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of Eleanor Blodgett. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The small vessel provides a human measure beneath the polar lights. Church gives the sky an extent that dwarfs this sign of travel, while ice and mountains divide the darkness below. The journey is present without becoming a detailed adventure story. Its scale is enough to establish how exposed a human enterprise can appear within such an extensive landscape.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1911.4.1

05 / 20

The Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone

Thomas Moran

1893-1901 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Thomas Moran. The Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone. Thomas Moran; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of George D. Pratt. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The foreground figures provide one measure of the canyon; the water far below provides another. Moran joins close rocks and vegetation to an immense downward view, using changing light to separate the intervening cliffs. The spectacle is carefully organised for an observer. Its breadth should not be mistaken for the absence of selection in how the landscape has been presented.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1928.7.1

06 / 20

The Girl I Left Behind Me

Eastman Johnson

c. 1872 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Eastman Johnson. The Girl I Left Behind Me. Eastman Johnson; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Museum purchase made possible in part by Mrs. Alexander Hamilton Rice in memory of her husband and by Ralph Cross Johnson. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Books are held firmly against the body while hair and clothing respond to the wind. Johnson contrasts the young woman's standing pose with forces moving around it. The title brings separation into the reading, but the picture does not identify the absent person or place. The visible opposition between holding still and being buffeted can carry the scene without completing that story.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1986.79

07 / 20

A Visit from the Old Mistress

Winslow Homer

1876 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Winslow Homer. A Visit from the Old Mistress. Winslow Homer; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of William T. Evans. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The visit is from the former enslaver, not a return by the Black women to her household. Homer's title therefore matters. The museum notes that one woman remains seated, withholding a deference once enforced under slavery. Space and posture register a changed encounter after emancipation, without implying that the participants' unequal history has been erased by sharing the room.

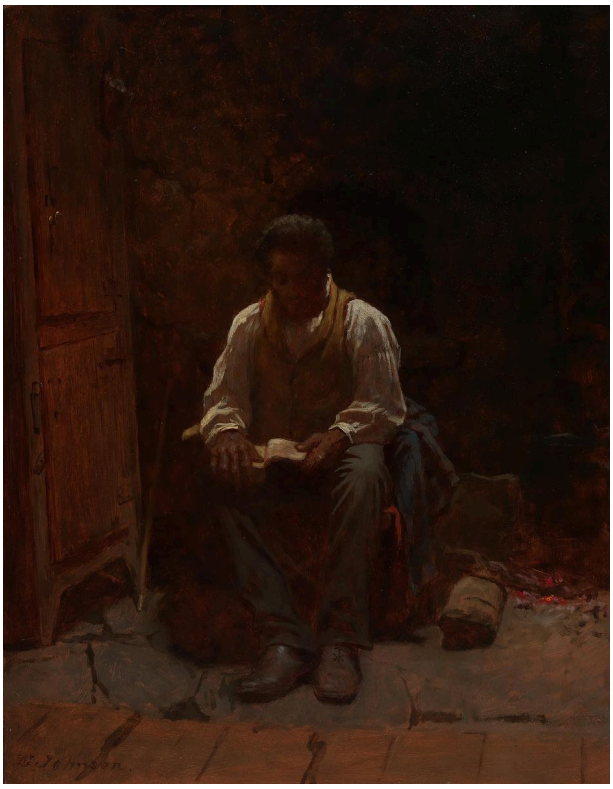
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1909.7.28

08 / 20

The Lord Is My Shepherd

Eastman Johnson

1863 · Oil on fiberboard · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Eastman Johnson. The Lord Is My Shepherd. Eastman Johnson; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of Mrs. Francis P. Garvan, Transfer from the National Museum of American History, Smithsonian Institution. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Light connects the open book with the man's hands and face, giving reading a concentrated physical presence. Johnson painted the work in 1863, during the Civil War. That setting prevents the activity from being merely a generic symbol of contemplation. The picture gives sustained attention to a Black reader at a time when freedom and access to learning were deeply contested.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1979.5.13

09 / 20

Brothers

Malvin Gray Johnson

1934 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Malvin Gray Johnson. Brothers. Malvin Gray Johnson; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of the Harmon Foundation. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Similar hats and overalls might initially make the boys seem a matched pair. Malvin Gray Johnson differentiates them through posture and expression as they sit beside the fence. The title establishes a relationship without making the individuals interchangeable. Looking for those small differences keeps the rural setting from turning two particular people into an anonymous illustration of country life.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1967.57.29

10 / 20

Self-Portrait

Malvin Gray Johnson

1934 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Malvin Gray Johnson. Self-Portrait. Malvin Gray Johnson; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of the Harmon Foundation. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Johnson places palette and brushes beside his likeness, with pictures and carved forms around him. The studio establishes a working identity rather than serving as a decorative backdrop. He appears among things made, used and studied. The portrait can therefore be read as a claim to artistic agency: the person represented is also someone who selects and produces representations.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1967.57.30

11 / 20

Elizabeth Winthrop Chanler

John Singer Sargent

1893 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



John Singer Sargent. Elizabeth Winthrop Chanler (Mrs. John Jay Chapman). John Singer Sargent; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of Chanler A. Chapman. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Patterned furnishings establish an elaborate social setting, but Sargent keeps the pale face and hands distinct from their surroundings. The sitter's held posture gives the encounter more weight than a catalogue of expensive materials would provide. Decoration remains visible without supplying her entire identity. The portrait asks attention to stay with a person who occupies the room, not merely with what the room contains.

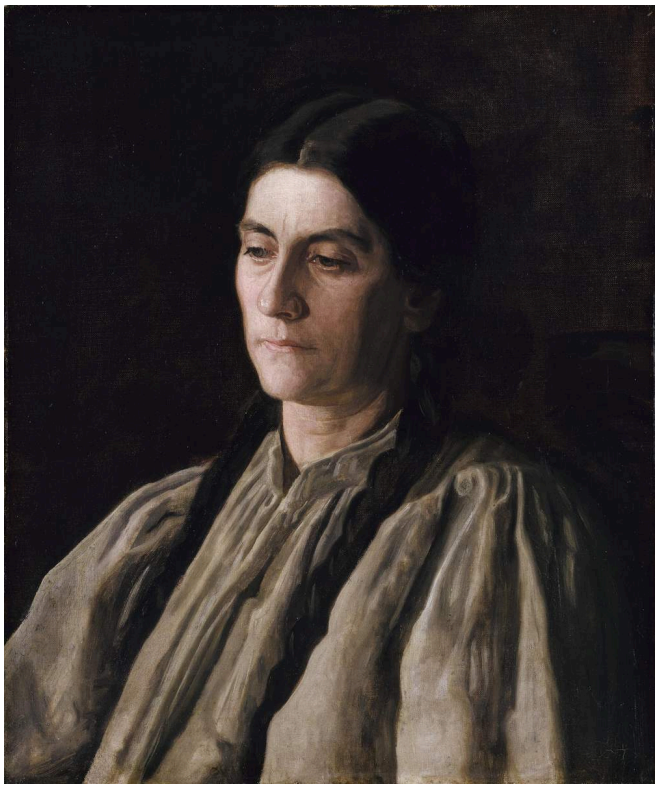
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1980.71

12 / 20

Mother: Annie Williams Gandy

Thomas Eakins

c. 1903 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Thomas Eakins. Mother (Annie Williams Gandy). Thomas Eakins; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Bequest of Mrs. Lucy G. Rodman through her sister Miss Helen W. Gandy. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The name in the title prevents “Mother” from becoming a wholly anonymous role. Eakins brings the face and hands out of dark clothing through restrained differences of tone. Little in the surrounding space competes with the seated presence. The image gives no need for a sentimental summary of motherhood: this particular woman's posture and appearance are enough to occupy it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1961.11.12

13 / 20

Melons and Morning Glories

Raphaelle Peale

1813 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Raphaelle Peale. Melons and Morning Glories. Raphaelle Peale; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of Paul Mellon. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The cut melon reveals what the whole fruit keeps inside: seeds, flesh and the relation between rind and interior. Peale places those differences beside curling stems and blossoms against darkness. Cutting changes what observation can establish. The still life offers more than a pleasing arrangement because it lets exterior and internal structure be considered together.

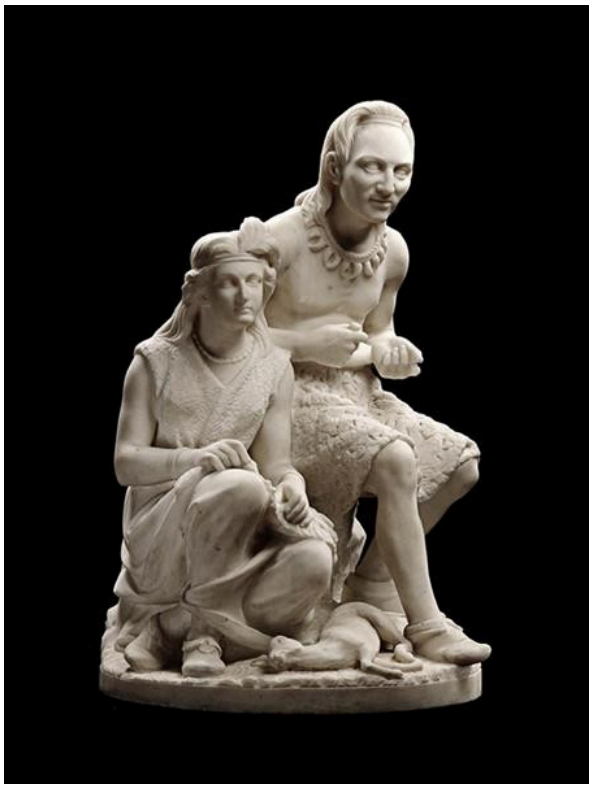
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1967.39.2

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The Old Arrow Maker

Edmonia Lewis

1872 · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Edmonia Lewis. Old Arrow Maker. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The seated man's work joins his hands and body to the younger woman beside him. Lewis gives a literary subject the tangible form of a marble group. The sculpture should be read as an interpretation, not as a scene whose apparent specificity proves firsthand documentation of Indigenous life. Its arrangement of figures is evidence of artistic choices, not a complete account of a community.

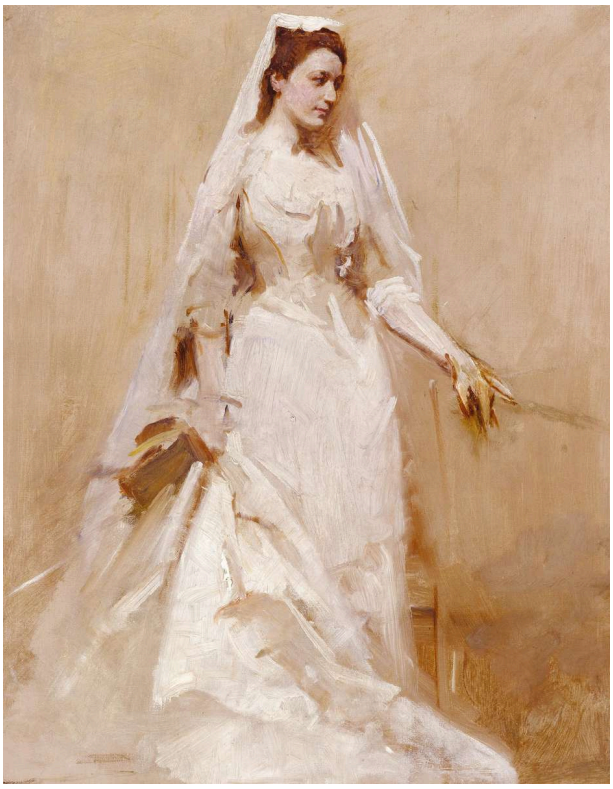
Object source · Open artwork

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The Bride

Abbott Handerson Thayer

c. 1895 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Abbott Handerson Thayer. A Bride. Abbott Handerson Thayer; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of John Gellatly. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

White clothing approaches the pale surroundings, while the face and dark hair remain distinct. Thayer varies how much definition the standing figure receives. The body's presence survives even where dress and light nearly merge. The title gives the figure a role, but the handling makes another question available: how much can be left unresolved before a likeness loses its hold?

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1929.6.111

16 / 20

Blind Spanish Singer

Robert Henri

1912 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Robert Henri. Blind Spanish Singer. Robert Henri; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of Mr. J.H. Smith. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The guitar gives the hands a practical relation to the seated body. Henri brings shirt, face and instrument out of the dark setting without supplying an elaborate performance space. The title identifies blindness, but the painting also represents a musician at work. Attention to that occupation keeps a physical condition from becoming the sitter's only available identity.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1967.41

17 / 20

Choctaw Woman

George Catlin

1834 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



George Catlin. A Choctaw Woman. George Catlin; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of Mrs. Joseph Harrison, Jr.. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The profile and open background make clothing and ornaments easy to distinguish. Catlin selects those visible features for an audience outside the sitter's community. They remain useful historical evidence, but they do not amount to her own account of herself. The portrait's particularity is best respected by acknowledging both what it preserves and whose choices govern its presentation.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1985.66.297

18 / 20

Smoking Horses

George Catlin

1835-1836 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



George Catlin. "Smoking Horses," a Curious Custom of the Sauk and Fox. George Catlin; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of Mrs. Joseph Harrison, Jr.. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The open circular arrangement lets an outside observer survey people and horses at once. Catlin's spacing clarifies the gathering while distancing the viewer from any individual participant's position. A visible arrangement is not yet an explanation of the ceremony. Its meaning requires Indigenous knowledge and historical context beyond what the painted distribution of bodies can establish on its own.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1985.66.463

19 / 20

Bitterroot

Mary Vaux Walcott

1915 · Watercolour on paper · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Mary Vaux Walcott. Bitterroot (Lewisia redivivia). Mary Vaux Walcott; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Gift of the artist. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Walcott separates buds, open flowers and narrow leaves against largely unpainted paper. The spacing makes small structures available for study without the competing growth of an outdoor setting. This clarity is a form of arrangement, not the absence of one. The botanical image shows how removing surroundings can reveal differences that a broader view would make difficult to examine.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1970.355.196

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Interior with Portraits

Thomas Le Clear

c. 1865 · Oil on canvas · Smithsonian American Art Museum



Thomas Le Clear. Interior with Portraits. Thomas Le Clear; Smithsonian American Art Museum, Museum purchase made possible by the Pauline Edwards Bequest. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The photographer bends beneath his equipment while the children hold their pose. Le Clear includes the apparatus and the studio's other images instead of presenting the likenesses as though they came into being unaided. Making a portrait becomes a visible activity. The painting gives attention to the conditions of representation as well as to the people being represented.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1993.6

Use the image with its limits intact

A portrait preserves an appearance selected by someone; a landscape organises a view from somewhere. Those limits do not make either useless. They make the questions more precise. Read individual collection records alongside these entries, particularly for historical depictions of communities, and check current display information before planning a visit around the selection.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed’s discussion of tone and arrangement gives practical questions for these pictures: where is the strongest light, which edges remain distinct, and how does a pose change when it is seen against a different background?

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Smithsonian American Art Museum: Masterpieces